



language of the educated in Europe. They also strove to establish an accurate text for the Bible—the famous humanist Erasmus regarded his Greek version of the New Testament as his major achievement. Humanists were often employed as tutors for the children of the rich and powerful, and they devised influential systems of education, focusing on subjects such as Latin, history, grammar, and rhetoric.

Feats in architecture

Architecture was an area in which the emulation of antiquity was most fruitful. One of the first great achievements of the Renaissance was the dome built for the cathedral in Florence by Filippo Brunelleschi. Brunelleschi had studied the ancient ruins in Rome, including the domed Pantheon (see pp.110–13), before embarking on the work. Completed in 1436, it was the largest dome ever built, a nearly miraculous feat of engineering as well as an aesthetic masterpiece. Domes were established as a crowning feature of the most ambitious Renaissance buildings, including St. Peter's Basilica in Rome,

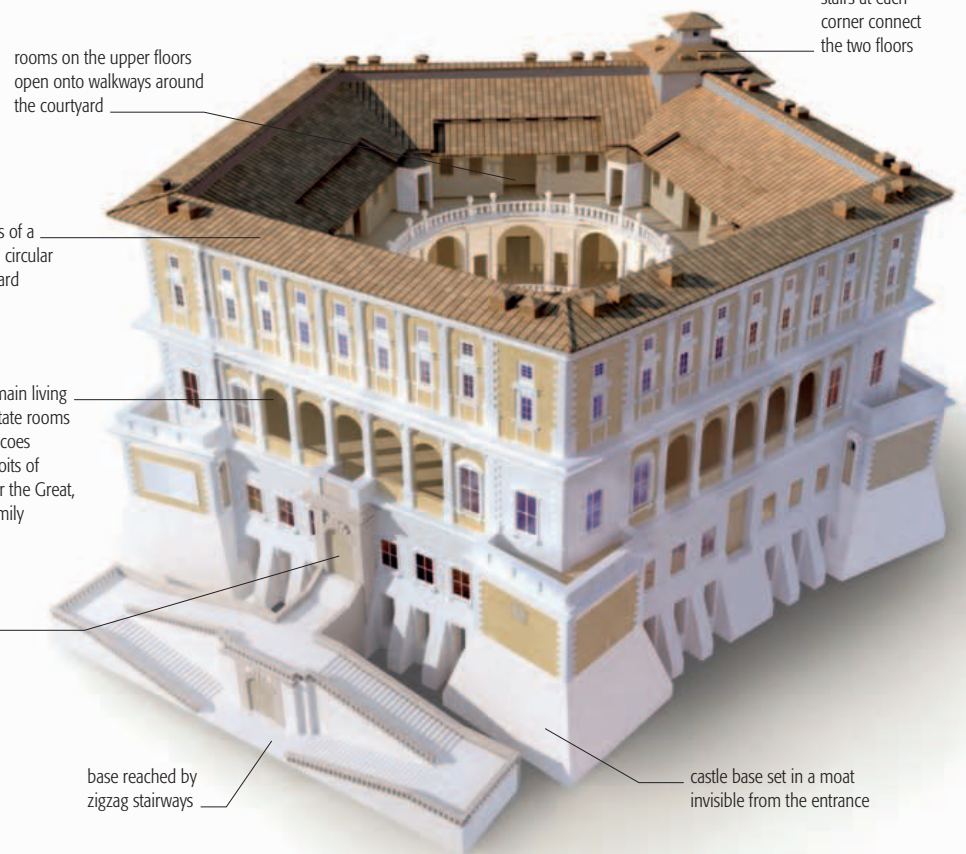
the palazzo consists of a pentagon around a circular colonnaded courtyard

the *piano nobile* (main living area) contains 12 state rooms decorated with frescoes illustrating the exploits of Hercules, Alexander the Great, and the Farnese family

fortresslike main entrance

base reached by zigzag stairways

stairs at each corner connect the two floors



The Birth of Venus

Painted around 1483, Sandro Botticelli's famous painting is unusual in having an overtly pagan (non-Christian) theme drawn from classical mythology. This was possible because it was produced for Lorenzo de Medici's private villa, not for public display.

Sistine ceiling

Commissioned by Pope Julius II in 1508, the ceiling of the Sistine Chapel in the Vatican is one of the masterworks of Florentine genius Michelangelo Buonarroti. Depicting scenes from the Old Testament, the frescoes took four years to complete.



while antique-style columns, arches, and statues (see pp.116–17) abounded in palaces, villas, and churches.

Artists and art

In painting and sculpture, the influence of ancient Greece and Rome was evident, for example, in the interest in an ideal version of the naked human body, seen especially in the painting and sculpture of Michelangelo Buonarroti. Artists also added classical pagan mythology to their subject matter (see pp.142–43), although usually for the private enjoyment of wealthy connoisseurs. Christian and biblical themes predominated in art for public display. As well as a desire to match the art of antiquity, however, there was a novel drive to represent the visual world with illusionistic precision. Flemish artists such as Jan van Eyck led the way with oil paintings that represented human features and the surfaces of objects with astounding accuracy of detail. In the second half of the 15th-century, Italian artists such as Piero della Francesca and Andrea Mantegna pioneered the use of linear perspective, intended to create a perfect illusion of three-dimensional space on a flat



Villa Farnese

Commissioned by the wealthy Farnese family, the Villa Farnese in Caprarola is considered a masterpiece of late Renaissance architecture. Architect Giacomo Barozzi de Vignola worked on the building from 1559–73.

CLASSICAL SCHOLAR (1466–1536)

ERASMUS

Dutch humanist Gerhard Gerhards, better known by his pen-name Erasmus, was ordained as a priest but lived as an independent scholar. In works such as *In Praise of Folly* (1509), he criticized the corruption of the Church, advocating a life governed by firm moral and religious principles. Erasmus's writings were among the first printed books to achieve a wide readership and they helped prepare the way for the Protestant Reformation (see pp.256–57).



“Our century, like a **golden age** has restored... the liberal arts.”

MARSILIO FICINO, FLORENTINE PHILOSOPHER, 1492